



MAN IN THE MIDDLE: Most sting stories swirl around Samajwadi Party leader Amar Singh

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VOICES

“If the CD was shot after Trustgate, proof against BJP is stronger. No SP man would dare to go to its office after the vote.”

UMA BHARATI, BHARATIYA JAN SHAKTI PARTY CHIEF

“THE PROBE SHOULD BE HANDED OVER TO AN AGENCY WITH STATUTORY POWERS.”

RAM JETHMALANI,
LEGAL EXPERT

“BJP’s former president figured in sting operations proving the party’s faulty credentials.”

JAYANTI NATARAJAN,
CONGRESS SPOKESPERSON

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come an accessory for the SP and act as an agent of fabricators has come as a shock to all those who have known her,” says Jaitley. The Lalu-Paswan sting shows Kulaste as saying that the BJP bosses L.K. Advani, Rajnath Singh and Jaitley were key backroom boys of the scandal. It goes on to say that Jaitley is behind the money brought to Parliament. Kulaste’s utterance that he barely knew Amar Singh beyond running into him on a few occasions was used to play down the BJP’s argument that Kulaste along with Aargal had visited Amar Singh’s house on the day of the trust vote.

Saxena, who is shown in all CDs as the conduit who carried the money, has emerged as the star cast. Jaitley, in an attempt to distance himself from him, says that Saxena’s son had mentioned Amar Singh’s official address as his father’s official address in a form submitted at a Delhi

University college. “This clearly shows that Saxena was working for Amar Singh and regularly contacted people on his behalf. There is bound to be more evidence of similar nature,” says Jaitley. Amar says his proximity to Saxena is due to the fact that he worked from the South Avenue flat allotted to his party colleague Shahid Siddiqui. “Saxena went away with Siddiqui the day he quit SP and joined the BSP,” he adds.

However, Saxena is shown saying that he had no idea about the contents of the bag he had been asked to deliver to Aargal. “I was shocked to see the cash when Aargal asked me to show what the bag contained,” Saxena says on the CD. The BJP, which was off to a good start by embarrassing the UPA Government by building up a credible offence after the trust vote, is clueless as more CDs were burnt by its rivals. Jaitley who played the sutradhar (narrator) in the post-trust vote tirade on the UPA, suddenly found himself among the long list of accused. Without a B-plan ready, the BJP assault is faltering. “The BJP is the king of stings. Its former national president Bangaru Laxman and one of the three MPs in the cash-for-vote controversy had figured in sting operations,” says Congress spokesperson Jayanti Natarajan.

BJP’s grouses against the channel’s decision not to telecast the sting also went unheard. In a two-page letter to Chatterjee, Advani complains that the footage of the alleged bribery of the three BJP MPs hours before the trust vote in Parliament was being treated as a “personal property” by the channel involved. A seven-member Lok Sabha panel has been constituted to look into the allegations. The saffron party has also demanded expansion of the committee, headed by Congress MP V. Kishore Chandra Deo, to give representation to more political parties. Though the committee has been given a deadline of August 11 to file its report, its chairman says they are in no hurry. The committee, which is in the process of examining the submitted CD, is now being flooded with more undercooked stings. Many doubt the capability of the committee to carry forward the investigations as it has no statutory powers. “The committee can do nothing. The investigation should be handed over to an agency with statutory powers or could be heard before a magistrate,” says legal expert Ram Jethmalani.

Politicians, who once fumed at sting operations, are now increasingly wielding the hidden camera to throw mud on their rivals. Unfortunately, on our Teflon-coated politicians, nothing ever sticks.